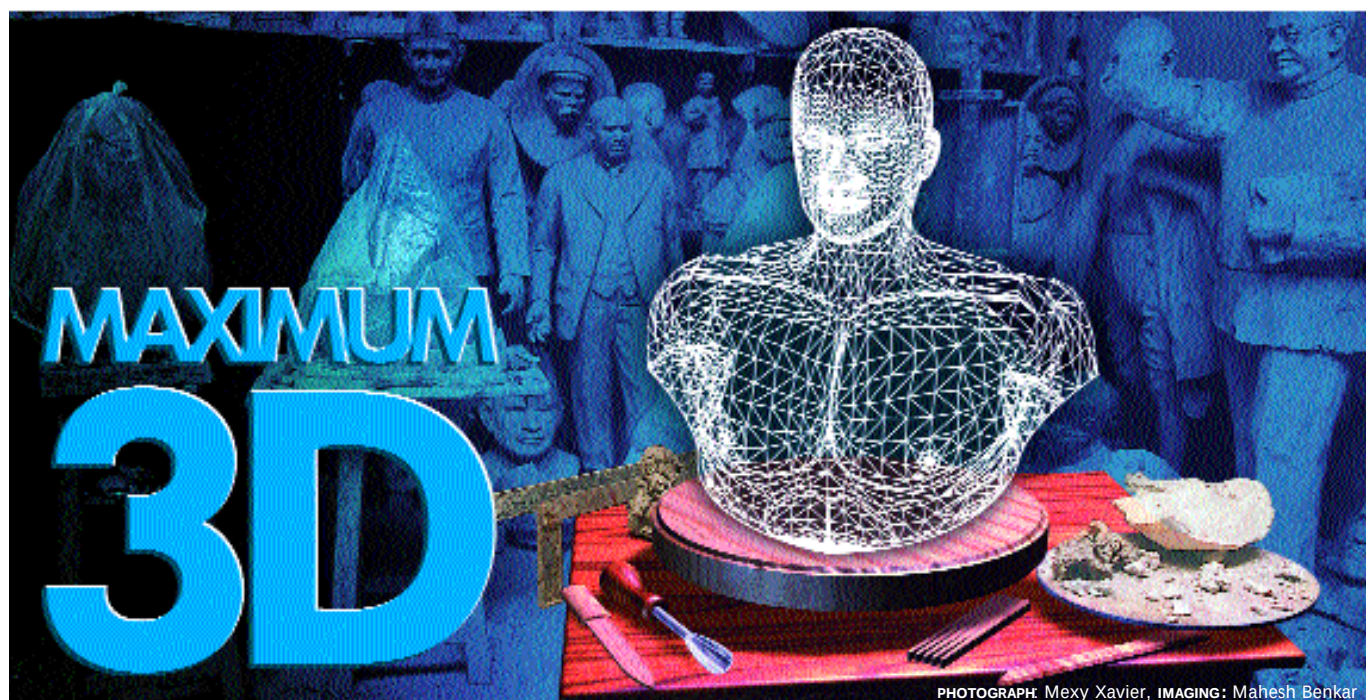




PHOTOGRAPH: Mexy Xavier, IMAGING: Mahesh Benkar

Is the latest version of 3ds max 5 worth migrating to?

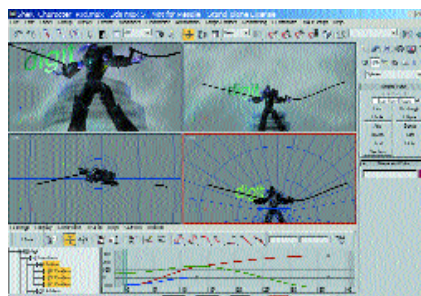
In the nascent Indian graphics industry, 3ds max is used as a stepping stone by all those who aspire to make a mark in this field. It has become a *de facto* tool, used to introduce beginners to the vast world of 3D modelling and animation. Yet, its great flexibility allows experts to perform incredibly detailed and complex tasks. It can be easily stated that no self-respecting graphics training institute would dare leave 3ds max out of its course, nor would a designer neglect to master it.

Most users would be familiar with 3ds max Release 4, where it attained the peak of its popularity. The question any user who is conversant with earlier editions would ask is: "How far has it come from the previous version?" We decided to take a look at the enhancements of this newly released product and also explore its worthiness.

User interface

In version 5 one can instantly notice the effort taken by the developers to ensure ease of workflow. The change in the interface becomes apparent the moment you start the program—hotkeys on the keyboard allow you to use the program much easier and faster as objects can be manipulated without going through the menu. A new splash screen shows you a randomly chosen tip about default keyboard shortcuts.

The menu has also been revamped. For instance, the Animation menu has all the controllers, hence, applying controls to the objects is faster and simpler than in the previous version (version 4.26), where you had to go to the Motion Panel to assign a control to the object.



3ds max 5 has a new intuitive interface

The menu bar also includes some additions. You can now access Advanced Lightning and Render to Texture from the menu bar itself, which makes the render process faster (*the details of this are discussed under 'Lightning and rendering enhancement'*).

The Isolate function of the previous versions has now been renamed Isolate Selection and is located in the Tools menu. The Snap option is now a part of the toolbar and no longer resides on the Animation bar. This change makes the

Snap option easier to access from the menu bar.

In version 5, the most frequently used functions directly reside on the interface, making them easier to access. An example would be the Curve Editor that resides on the Timeline. The Interactive Update option available in this version allows you to preview the changes made to the objects directly; you can also directly assign controls to the object. An all-new Dope Sheet lets you change the timings of an animation without worrying about the animation curve (the path of an animation). You can also copy frames from one object and paste them on another through the time select mode, a feature that will be appreciated by animators.

The Transform gizmos for Position, Rotation and Scale have been redesigned, thus providing more flexibility and feedback: a red, green, blue colour scheme helps you associate the gizmo's components along the XYZ axes; the size of the gizmo changes as it gets closer or farther away from the point of view of the camera; the Scale gizmo now includes plane handles and scaling feedback through stretching of the gizmo itself.

The new Lasso Selection tool allows you to select multiple objects at one go, while the Material Editor has two new options, viz. Ink and Paint for cartoon shading and Translucent Shader which can

